

Festive spread

UMMI ABDULLAH

UMMI ABDULLAH lays out a treat for Bakrid.



Panchara Patta

A light honeycomb-like snack

- Ingredients

Eggs 6
Raw rice 250 gm
Oil 1/2 litre
For the garnishing:
Sugar
Raisins
Banana

- Method

Soak the rice in water for three to four hours. Wash, drain and grind to a smooth paste, adding water. Add four eggs and half a cup of water to the paste and beat well with an egg beater (or with a wooden math) till very frothy and air bubbles appear. Heat three-fourths of the oil in a vessel. Remove the bubbles from the rice mixture in another vessel. Again beat the mixture till bubbles surface. Now pour four to five ladles full of bubbles into the hot oil. (No rice mixture should be used). Again collect the bubbles and pour on top of the first layer in the oil, which will be set by now. Continue the process till it becomes two to 2 1/2 inches thick. Each layer should be poured when the earlier one sets and becomes light brown. Remove the *Panchara Patta* from the oil and place in a colander to drain. Add the remaining oil and make three to four more *Panchara Pattas* the same way. When there are fewer bubbles, add an egg at a time and beat. If the mixture becomes too thick, add a little more water.

Keep the *Panchara Pattas* in the colander for two days and use. Arrange all the *Panchara Pattas* in a serving dish and sprinkle the sugar and raisins.



CULINARY history is dotted with instances/accidents with happy endings. A classic example, of course, is the origin of the all-time favourite Crepe Suzette. History has it that on one occasion when Edward VII, Prince of Wales, ordered Chef Henri Charpentiere for a dish of crepe, the latter was determined to impress his royal patron with something truly special. But he got rather carried away by his enthusiasm to make a sauce that would really stand out and the result was that the cordial-rich sauce caught fire.

Desperately, the chef plunged the crepes into the boiling liquid, doused the entire melange with more alcohol, let the whole thing go aflame and, unwilling to make His Royal Highness wait any longer, rushed the dish to the table. The Prince was charmed and decreed that this spectacular dish be named after his host's daughter: Suzette.

There are many other such examples, but for us in India, it's specially interesting to know that yogurt — that indispensable, ubiquitous feature of the Great Indian Kitchen — also came to be quite by accident. According to historians, yogurt making probably originated with nomadic tribes in the Balkans thousands of years ago when on a warm night, some "friendly bacteria" (*Lactobacillus acidophilus* and *Streptococcus lactis* to their scientific pals) worked their magic on a bowl of leftover milk, transforming it to semi-solid, creamy consistency, with that prized sweetly acidic, mild flavour. The nomads of course, were quick to realise that this was the answer to the problem of milk preservation and from there to the cooking pots was a matter of time.

Bapsi Nariman's **Cooking with Yogurt** is, to quote the author, "an experiment with yogurt as a culinary act". At first, an entire book dedicated to yogurt-based recipes may seem excessive, but what one has to keep in mind is yogurt's long and varied history that has inevitably given rise to countless dishes that depend on the addition — sometimes of a dollop and sometimes much more — of this dairy product. In India alone, records of yogurt making go back thousands

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